



KAMKISHAN

Bihar's Shotgun WEDDINGS

The practice of men abducted by prospective in-laws for marriage is an established custom in parts of the state

| By Amitabh Srivastava |

Lalbabu Prasad, 16, looks like a nocturnal animal caught in a pair of headlights. He is irrevocably grim and unwilling to come out of his shell. Prasad, who stays with his maternal grandparents after the death of his father, a constable in Jharkhand, has reasons

to be wary of strangers. In May 2009, he was abducted at gunpoint and was forced to marry a 13-year-old girl, Babita. His friend Praveen—who tried to come to his rescue—died when the kidnappers fired their weapons to scare him away. Prasad was considered eligible for abduction since he had been appointed as a child constable in Jharkhand on

compensatory grounds. He gets Rs 5,000 a month and will be accommodated in the Jharkhand Police once he attains adulthood. Hours later, when the police rescued Prasad, he was already married. They arrested Babita and her mother Kaushalya Devi for abduction. Babita's father Krishna Yadav, brother Anil Kumar and other accused are still absconding.

This was literally a shotgun marriage but in Bihar such marriage abductions are so common that they don't raise eyebrows. The practice of men abducted by prospective in-laws for marriage to their daughters is an established custom known as "Pakaraua Vivah," which translates roughly as capture and marry off. Many of these marriages survive. For instance, the family of 13-year-old Rajesh Rai of Patna has